

FIFA Soccer 2005

FIFA 2004 was not a good game. Actually, that was a huge understatement. OK, it sucked. Real bad. I actually preferred to play FIFA 2003 instead of FIFA 2004. Now EA's come out with FIFA 2005. Is it more of the same, or is it any good? Will it be a waste of your money? Hell, no!

This Is The New Shit

FIFA 2005 is one helluva game. It comes with the customary 350 licences, including 20 leagues, 40 national teams and over 15,000 players. All rosters are also up to date, with all transfers up to October 1, 2004 reflected in the game.

There's an all new interface, which is a real saving grace, because FIFA 2004's interface... well, the less said the better.

Also, for the first time since FIFA 2002, 2005 comes with a Creation Centre built in, so your days of downloading them are gone. It's detailed to the core.

Another nifty feature is the EA Store. By fulfilling certain objectives, you earn points that allow you to unlock certain items. So you have alternate kits, different balls, songs and stadia to be unlocked—even celeb referee Pierluigi Colina! All this is just the tip of the iceberg. What really makes the game so darn good is the First Touch model and ultra-realistic gameplay.



2005 realistically simulates your first touch of the ball

They Call It The Real Deal

EA has introduced, for the very first time, a First Touch model that realistically simulates your player's first touch of the ball. The first touch depends on how the player is positioned and the angle at which the ball is played to him, giving you the most realistic gameplay ever in any FIFA game.

Now you can plan your movements before you receive the ball, ensuring that the opposition's defence can't get anywhere near you. The game's a lot less monotonous, because it allows you to bring variation into your play and lets you try out some of those cool moves you saw on TV.

Everything about the gameplay has been improved. Take the AI. I could swear they read your mind sometimes, because the way they cut your most disguised 'through' ball is just unbelievable.

Another very welcome improvement is the player's ball control at the touchline. If the ball has just deflected off your defender and rolled to a standstill just on the touchline, you and an



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opponent will now race towards it. In 2004, you'd kick the ball out if you ran at it because of your momentum. In 2005, however, you have complete control of the ball in such situations. Players will even slide and try to keep the ball in play if it's rolling out. The game oozes realism, while still being fun to play.

Sweet Is The Fruit Of Patience

EA has also put in a whole new Career mode into 2005. This time around, your career lasts fifteen seasons, instead of just five. There are five different regions where you can begin your career, each with its own major leagues.

So England comes under one region, Spain under another, and so on. You start off at the teams in the lowest leagues and have to build a reputation to get a job at a top-level club. You have to keep winning trophies and your Job Security meter up.

Whoa, She's Beautiful!

EA has had the best football title for a long time when it comes to graphics, and this time it's no different. The graphics are jaw-dropping. 3D grass, accurate shadows, and the players look better than ever. However, audio is the one disappointing thing about the game.

One feature in FIFA 2005 that's both realistic and annoying is player retirements. From age 32 onwards, players start to retire and are replaced by randomly-generated characters having their names, skills and looks similar to those they're replacing. While this does make the game more realistic, it also makes it very annoying, because by the time you have enough managerial prestige to get into a top club, the best players are gone! Another irritating feature is the 'Load Replay' menu. You can save all the replays you want, but the menu only lets you see 13 of them.

Basically, there are plenty of ways EA could have improved FIFA 2005, but that still doesn't stop it from being one great game. It really is a must-buy, especially for FIFA fans who gave up on the franchise after FIFA 2004. Go get it now!

FIFA Soccer 2005

Publisher **Electronic Arts**

Developer **EA Canada**

Web site www.easports.com/games/fifa2005

System requirements **700 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, 32 MB video card,**

800 MB free hard disk space, DirectX 9.0b

Distributor **Gayatri Impex Pvt Ltd**

Price **Rs 1,299**

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